



Slower to the Same Window: A Nomination-Panel Process for a Charity Retailer's "Find of the Week" Pick, Before and After It Replaces a Single Rostered Volunteer's Choice

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Abstract. A charity retailer's weekly "Find of the Week" window display has, at every op shop in the network this paper studies, long been the call of whichever volunteer is rostered on donation-sort day. The network's regional coordinating office recently replaced that call with a one-page nomination form, a rotating three-volunteer panel, and a published rationale, framed as making the choice more consistent and representative. We report a twenty-four-week field study across nineteen op shops, comparing the winning item's category, the volume of volunteer input the choice drew on, and the time from an item's nomination to its display, for twelve weeks either side of the changeover. Winning-item category — coded practical/wearable against novelty/curio by two independent raters (Cohen's $\kappa = .81$) — held flat across the changeover (57.1% practical before, 54.5% after; not significant), as did the weekly volume of volunteer input the eventual winner drew on. What moved was time: median decision-to-publish latency rose from same-day to a four-day median within the first post-changeover week. A parallel rollout withholding the panel's published rationale from six shops left that latency unchanged. We read the panel as adding process to a choice without moving the choice it was convened to make more representative.

Introduction

A community charity retailer's shop floor runs on volunteer judgement more than on policy. Stock is priced by feel, seasonal lines are pulled by whoever notices the season turning, and a shop's single weekly flourish — a "Find of the Week" item propped in the window, chosen from that week's donations — has, at every site in the regional network this paper studies, been the call of whichever volunteer happened to be rostered on donation-sort day. The choice costs nothing to make and answers to nobody; a shopper walking past either likes the window or doesn't.

In 2025 the network's regional coordinating office replaced the rostered volunteer's pick with a formal process: a one-page nomination form any shift volunteer could complete, a panel of

three volunteers rotating weekly across the region, a three-criterion scoring rubric (condition, rarity, styling potential), and a published rationale posted beside the winning item. The stated aim was consistency and representativeness — a shop's window should reflect more than one volunteer's taste. Whether it does, in the sense of changing what actually gets chosen, is a separate question from whether it looks, from the coordinating office's chair, like it should.

This paper reports a twenty-four-week field study spanning the changeover, comparing what the window held before the panel existed against what it holds after, across three measures: the category of item that wins, the volume of volunteer opinion the choice draws on, and how long the choice takes to reach the glass.

Three contributions follow, each stated with the caution the design supports.

- We report a matched before/after field comparison of an informal, single-volunteer merchandising choice against the same choice made by a formal nomination panel, across a charity retail network's full site set.
- We separate what a formal panel process changes about a choice from what it merely re-narrates: category composition and input volume held flat where latency did not.
- We test, via a rationale-write-up ablation at a subset of sites, whether the added process's cost sits in the deliberation or in its documentation; our results suggest, with appropriate caution, that the deliberation is where the time goes.

Related work

Two traditions bear on a decision made once informally, then made again with more apparatus. One asks whether a more formal evaluation process changes an outcome; the other asks whether it merely changes how legitimate the outcome looks.

On outcomes, peer assessment is the most heavily studied formal/informal pair in the literature: agreement between peer and instructor marks runs moderate to strong across disciplines [1], though what a rater attends to, and what they report noticing about their own judgement, is not fixed by a rubric alone [2], [3]. A panel convened specifically to formalise a judgement does not thereby guarantee it converges on a stable answer: replicate-sample testing of wine-competition judges found the large majority unable to reproduce their own medal-tier score for the same wine served twice blind [4], and extraneous, non-substantive factors — session order, elapsed time since a break — have been shown to move outcomes in a formally constituted panel setting with real stakes [5].

On legitimacy, a formal participatory process can read as representative while changing little about who holds the decision, a distinction the participation literature has drawn since its foundational typology of degrees of citizen power [6]; deliberative mini-publics raise perceived legitimacy mainly where their recommendation is visibly followed [7], and participation more broadly delivers its promised legitimacy only

where it is consequential rather than symbolic [8]. Procedural-fairness judgements, separately, carry weight independent of the outcome they accompany [9], [10], which is one reason a slower, more visible process can read as fairer even where it changes nothing it was convened to change.

Volunteer-run community institutions generate their own informal governance well before any coordinating body writes it down: community gardens converge on shared, unwritten norms of maintenance and use through routine co-presence rather than through any charter [11], and the social benefits volunteers report from that co-presence vary more with a project's organisational design than with its stated purpose [12], [13]. Formalising a decision made inside such an institution does not obviously formalise its pace: bureaucratic decision-making has been shown to speed up or slow down for reasons uncoupled from a decision's substance [14], administrative procedure and organisational performance move together in ways red-tape research treats as at best loosely coupled [15], and a decision can be substantively the same one whether the process producing it reads as decisionist, technocratic, or genuinely deliberative [16]. Prior work at this University has found a comparable pattern twice: a formal appeals process moved a household chore wheel's record sharply closer to who actually did the work, without moving how much work got done [17], and informal noticeboard postings were found to harden into settled-sounding rulings distinguishable chiefly by how fast they closed, despite no resident holding any authority to enforce one [18].

Method

Setting. The study ran across nineteen op shops in a single regional charity retail network, each running a weekly rostered-volunteer schedule and a shared "Find of the Week" window tradition predating this study by several years. Every shop drew on the same regional donations pipeline and had, before the study, left the weekly window pick to whichever volunteer was rostered for that day's donation sort.

Design. The twenty-four-week deployment split into a twelve-week baseline, during which the rostered-volunteer pick continued unchanged, and a twelve-week post-changeover period, during which all nineteen shops ran the

network's new nomination-panel process: any shift volunteer could submit a one-page nomination for a donated item, a rotating panel of three volunteers (drawn weekly from a region-wide roster, never from the nominating item's own shop) scored each nomination on three criteria — condition, rarity, styling potential — and the week's highest-scoring nomination was displayed with a published one-paragraph rationale beside it.

Category coding. Two raters, blind to study period, independently coded each week's winning item into one of two categories, **practical/wearable** or **novelty/curio**, from a photograph and a one-line donation description; inter-rater agreement was substantial (Cohen's $\kappa = .81$), and disagreements were resolved by a third coder.

Input-volume measure. Before the changeover, a research assistant shadowing the rostered volunteer's sort logged every instance of another volunteer voicing an opinion on that week's eventual winner; after the changeover, the same measure was the count of nominations lodged, network-wide, for the eventual winner's category that week. The two measures differ in mechanism, a substitution this paper returns to in Limitations, but both count the volume of volunteer input a winning choice drew on.

Decision-to-publish latency. For nomination i ,

$$L_i = d_{\text{published}}(i) - d_{\text{submitted}}(i),$$

where $d_{\text{submitted}}$ is the date an item entered consideration (donation-sort date, pre-changeover; nomination-form date, post-changeover) and $d_{\text{published}}$ is the date it appeared in the window with its rationale, if any.

Rationale-write-up ablation. From week 13, six of the nineteen shops (assigned by the coordinating office to a lighter-touch regional trial, not by this study) ran the full panel and rubric but skipped the published rationale write-up; the remaining thirteen ran the process as designed.

Results

Winning-item category holds flat. Figure 1 compares the winning item's category composition either side of the changeover across 441 weekly picks (219 before, 222 after; three shop-weeks lost to public-holiday closures). Practical/wearable items won 57.1% of weeks before the panel and 54.5% after ($\chi^2(1) = 0.31$, $p = .58$), a difference well inside the range Cohen's $\kappa = .81$

coding would be expected to produce by chance alone.

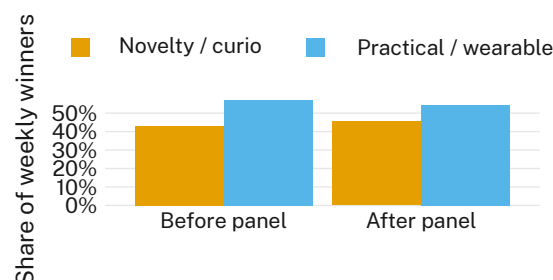


Figure 1: Winning-item category held at 57.1% practical/wearable before the nomination panel and 54.5% after (n.s.).

Input volume holds flat too. Before the changeover, the shadowing assistant logged a mean of 2.4 other volunteers' opinions per week on the eventual winner; after, a mean of 2.6 nominations were lodged, network-wide, for the winning category each week ($t(438) = 0.78$, $p = .44$). The panel did not draw on a visibly larger pool of volunteer judgement than the rostered pick already had; it drew on much the same pool, filed on paper.

Latency moved, sharply and immediately. Figure 2 plots mean decision-to-publish latency by week. Median latency was same-day (0 days) throughout the twelve-week baseline and rose to a median of 4 days (IQR 3–6) within the first post-changeover week, holding at that level for the remaining eleven weeks.

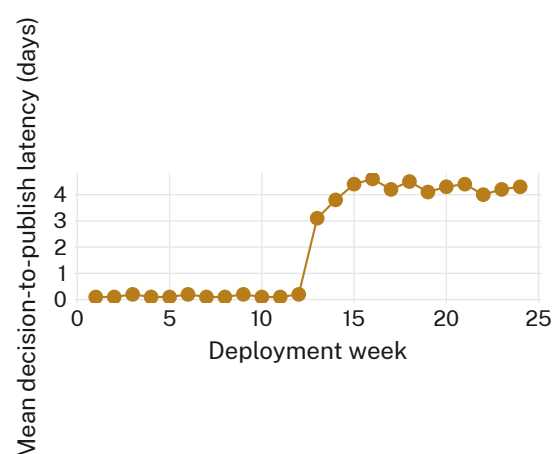


Figure 2: Mean decision-to-publish latency rose from same-day to a four-day median in the nomination panel's first week and stayed there.

The rationale write-up changes nothing further. Figure 3 compares latency at the thirteen full-process shops against the six shops piloting the process without a published rationale. The distributions are close to indistinguishable (medians of 4 days either way; Mann–Whitney $U = 34.5$, $p = .61$); we retain the rationale write-up for the transparency it offers shoppers, though the ablation gives no measured reason to expect it costs the process any of its own time.

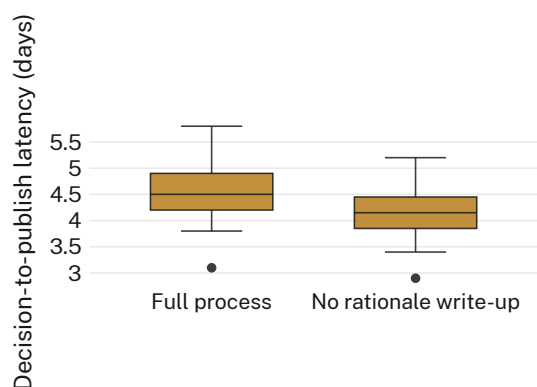


Figure 3: Decision-to-publish latency is statistically indistinguishable between shops that published a rationale and shops that didn't (n.s.).

Discussion

Read together, the three results locate the panel's cost precisely: not in what it chooses, and not obviously in how many volunteers it consults, but in how long the choosing now visibly takes. A window that used to hold this week's find by the same afternoon now holds it, on average, four days later, wrapped in a published paragraph explaining why. Two comparable University findings recur here. A household chore wheel's assignment record moved sharply closer to who actually did the work once a formal appeals process existed, though the work itself did not change [17]; an apartment lobby noticeboard was found to harden informal postings into settled-sounding rulings distinguishable mainly by how fast they closed, with no resident holding any power to enforce one [18]. All three findings share a shape the participation literature already has a name for: a process can look, from outside, like it has moved decision-making power somewhere new, while the choice itself tracks almost exactly where it would otherwise have landed [6], [8]. Our results suggest, with appropriate caution, that a coordinating office wanting a more representative window already

has one; what it is buying with the panel is documentation, not a different afternoon.

Limitations

The input-volume measure changed mechanism across the changeover — shadowed informal comment before, filed nominations after — a substitution this design cannot fully separate from the changeover itself, though both measures moved in the same flat direction, which we read as some reassurance against the substitution alone driving the null. Shops were not randomly assigned to the rationale-write-up ablation; the coordinating office's own selection of six lighter-touch sites may correlate with qualities of those shops this study cannot rule out, though the consistency of the latency null across both arms limits how much of a confound could plausibly explain it. Category coding rested on a photograph and a one-line description rather than the physical item, a proxy we consider adequate for a two-category split but not for a finer taxonomy.

Conclusion

Across twenty-four weeks and nineteen shops, replacing a rostered volunteer's window pick with a nomination form, a rotating panel, and a published rationale left the winning item's category and the volume of volunteer opinion behind it essentially where they already were, and added four days to the choosing. The distinction matters for any coordinating body treating a new process as evidence that a choice has become more considered, when the more defensible reading is that the choice was already representative enough for the process to have little left to move beyond its own paperwork. Future work should test whether a longer deployment, or a panel drawn from entirely outside the rostered-volunteer pool, changes what a network's windows actually hold, rather than only how long they take to say so.

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